Record Your Father's Care Needs Today and the Signs Worth Watching

Four prompts to write down the help your father gets now, see what the home arrangement is counting on, name the changes that would be worth a conversation with a professional, and list the questions to ask then.

Where you are

Your father manages at home with a little help, and nothing has gone wrong. Relatives have opinions about where this is heading. You'd rather have a clear record of what he needs now than an argument about what he'll need in five years.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can state what support your father requires today, name the specific changes that should send you back to a professional, and list the questions you'd ask when that happens.

A one-page record with three headings: Help He Gets Today, Changes Worth a Conversation, and Questions We'd Ask Then.

Before you start

- Notes about an ordinary week for your father, including what he does alone.
- A list of who helps him and with what.
- Anything a doctor or therapist has said recently about his health or mobility. A couple of sentences each is plenty.

PROMPT 1

Write down today's help

WHY THIS MATTERS

Families skip this because nothing is wrong. But a record of what your father needs now is the only thing that will let you recognize a change later, instead of arguing about whether one happened.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your notes on a normal week for him.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My father lives at home with some help, and nothing is wrong right now. Here is an ordinary week for him:

> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Make a table of the tasks in his week with columns: TASK, DOES IT HIMSELF, HELP HE GETS, FROM WHOM, and HOW OFTEN. Fill in HOW OFTEN only where I've told you; otherwise write NOT RECORDED. Keep the things he does alone in the table; they matter as much as the help. Don't guess what he might need next year, and don't suggest adding anything. I want a picture of today.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A table where most rows say DOES IT HIMSELF. That's good news, and it's worth having in writing.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask your father to look it over. He'll correct things you got wrong.

PROMPT 2

See what the home arrangement is counting on

WHY THIS MATTERS

Help at home usually rests on things nobody has said out loud: he still drives, the neighbor is home during the day, the stairs are fine. Each one is an assumption, and assumptions change without warning.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The table from the first prompt.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is the help my father gets at home and who provides it:
>
> [PASTE THE TABLE FROM PROMPT 1]
>
> Show me what this arrangement is counting on. Give me three columns: WHAT WE'RE COUNTING ON, WHO OR WHAT IT DEPENDS ON, and WHAT I'VE BEEN TOLD ABOUT HOW LONG IT CAN CONTINUE. In the last column use only what I've said; if I've said nothing, write NOT DISCUSSED. Include the quiet ones, like his driving, the stairs, and the neighbor who happens to be home in the daytime. Then list the items marked NOT DISCUSSED as conversations to have.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

The NOT DISCUSSED items. Each one is a conversation you can have now, calmly.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Have one of those conversations this month, with the person it concerns.

PROMPT 3

Name the changes worth a conversation

WHY THIS MATTERS

You can't predict how your father's needs will change, and you shouldn't try. What you can do is agree now on which changes would make you pick up the phone, and whose number you'd dial.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of the first two prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is my father's current support and what it depends on:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 AND 2]
>
> List the changes I could actually notice that would be worth a conversation with a professional. Think about changes in him, changes in the people who help, and changes in the house. For each one, name who I'd talk to: his doctor, a nurse, a therapist, a pharmacist, or a care consultant. Group them by that person. Don't tell me what any change would mean for his health or what care he would then need. I want a watch list, not a forecast.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Changes specific enough that two relatives would agree whether one had happened.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Share the watch list with whoever sees your father most often.

PROMPT 4

Date it and keep it to one page

WHY THIS MATTERS

A record, a watch list, and a set of questions fit on one page. That page is what you'll pull out when a change happens, so you start from facts instead of from fear.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've put together about my father's support:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Put it on one page with three headings: HELP HE GETS TODAY, CHANGES WORTH A CONVERSATION, and QUESTIONS WE'D ASK THEN. Under the third heading, include questions about what kind of help or capabilities we might need to look into if things change, written as questions, not answers. Do not include a predicted path of care, a suggested setting, or a timeline. Keep every NOT RECORDED and NOT DISCUSSED label where it is.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page with no predictions on it, only what's true today and what you'd do if it changed.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Date the page, keep it, and begin the next step below.

Make today's record complete

A written record of what your father needs today is only useful if it's complete. The care interview asks about every area of his daily life, including the ones that are fine right now, and turns the answers into a Family Care Profile. When something changes, that profile is what you and a professional compare against.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›